Wayne Miner Health Center Not Closing Dr. Samuel Rodgers Reveals Future Plans

Editor's Note: In THE CALL of January 5, the president of the National Association of Neighborhood Health Centers called plans of the federal government to phase out funding of neighborhood health centers "a tragic blow to the millions of medically underserved people in America."

The Wayne Miner Neighborhood Health Center, 825 Euclid Ave., is one of the health centers that may be involved. The Wayne Miner director, Dr. Samuel U. Rodgers, was interviewed this week concerning the future of the Health Center. The interview was conducted by a Wayne Miner staff member, Jim Nunnelly, who complied a list of questions most frequently-asked since the appearance of THE CALL's article.

The questions and answers which will give readers a comprehensive view of the situation at the Wayne Miner Health Center, follow:

Question: Dr. Rodgers, what is the Wayne Miner Neighborhood Health Center?

Dr. Rodgers: Wayne Miner is a community-based health activity that provides many necessary health services for people in our area, medical services, dental services, social services, home care services, transportation, pharmacy, etc.

Nunnelly: What makes Wayne Miner different from other Medical Care facilities?

Dr. Rodgers: I think the big difference is that it is community-based and community-controlled.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers, lately we've heard a lot about the Wayne Miner Neighborhood Health Center having to face a cutback in funds. How did all this begin?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, it's apparently a part of a national policy in terms of reducing the overall spending in the U. S. and there was obviously some judgment made about where the reductions are to take place. If there are reasons other than that, I don't know: but we are a part of what amounts to an attempt to reduce the spending in the health area.

Nunnelly: You mentioned policy. Briefly explain this proposed policy.

Dr. Rodgers: You are well aware of headlines daily about the national budget and that it's never balanced - simply because of excessive spending; therefore, reducing health center budgets somehow seem to be part of an attempt to reduce the imbalance in the national budget; but we have some feelings that they could reduce the spending in other places. But this we have not been asked to help decide.

Nunnelly: From whom and why did you get this official word?

Dr. Rodgers: Our directions come from a branch of HEW that deals specifically with neighborhood health centers and the latest word came in a telegram about the first of December, stating that health centers would probably be reduced about 18 percent in the budget beginning in August.

Nunnelly: In essence, what did the policy say?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, the policy stated, that there would be less money available for neighborhood health centers and other related types of care. The amount would be roughly 18 percent and this would be effective in August, 1973.

Nunnelly: What effect will this cutback on funds have on the Wayne Miner services?

Dr. Rodgers: Obviously it's going to reduce a lot of the activity here. We cannot maintain the present level of activity with that much reduction in money.

Nunnelly: Is there any likelihood that the center itself may be closed?

Dr. Rodgers: I don't think it's going to be closed in the immediate future. If this is not repeated in another year, I know we won't be closed. However, we're fearful that this reduction may be repeated next year.

Nunnelly: Last year you suffered a similar situation in a cutback of funds. How will this one compare with the one last year?

Dr. Rodgers: The one of last year was about half that amount ($300,000) and did not make near the impression that this one will make. If, in effect, it goes through.

Nunnelly: In essence, what did happen last year in the cutback?

Dr. Rodgers: We eliminated some positions that were not filled and few that were filled. But these were marginal positions that did not have any direct relationship to patient care.

Nunnelly: Did this reduction have any effect on your services?

Dr. Rodgers: No demonstrable effect on the patient care portion.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers, how many persons does the Wayne Miner Health Center serve?

Dr. Rodgers: We serve around 25,000 people of which we have registered 22,000.

Nunnelly: What is some of the activity for the year? In other words, how many patient visits do you average per month?

Dr. Rodgers: We average monthly over 6,000 patient encounters in the Health Center. Nunnelly: Has this been a leveled off figure in the five years of activity?

Dr. Rodgers: No, every month seems to be a bigger month.

Nunnelly: Does this meet with your expectations, let's say, from four years ago?

Dr. Rodgers: Yes, it's what we expected.

Nunnelly: Would you say you are on schedule and would you comment a little further on that?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, we think we are on schedule. Expectations at the beginning were that by the end of the fifth year we would have registered the total number persons in the area. So, at the rate we are going by the end of the fifth operational year we would have approximately 25,000 people registered.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers, obviously, by having a health center of this size, you've become quite well-known in health circles, that reminds me that last week you were appointed medical director for the Planned Parenthood. Can you comment on this?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, it's a related activity. It doesn't call for any great deal of time on the job, and it's more a directional job. There's no salary pay for it. As a matter of fact it possibly would be very helpful to the neighborhood health center and to the rest of the community.

Nunnelly: We've heard a lot of talk about plans for a national health insurance, and national health strategy. We've heard the mayor make comments about the city health situation. Can you bring this to bear with the development plans for Wayne Miner?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, we are certain that in the future there will be a national health insurance, the question is whether it will be two, three, or four years away. We are prepared to become a part of a national policy. We are already able, in terms of the basic structure and systems, to change to the Health Maintenance Organization.

Nunnelly: Going back to this cutback in money. Recently your privilege to use the government-owned cars was taken away from you. What have you done in this regard and what is your position on this matter of the GSA cars?

Dr. Rodgers: It necessitates an increased expense. We had to replace the government-owned cars with some that we are leasing. Cost has approximately doubled. Therefore, we have fewer cars and less ability to transport patients.

Nunnelly: Now you are saying "transport patients," Was this the main use or the only use for the cars?

Dr. Rodgers: Yes, for patients and their relatives. For no other reasons.

Nunnelly: At what level of activity were the cars being used? In other words how many patients do you transport?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, it's hard to be exact. Every month we transport as many as 4,500 to 5,000 persons. These are not always patients because some relatives come along with patients to see the doctor.

Nunnelly: Why is transportation such a big element in your center?

Dr. Rodgers: Because otherwise, the patients would have no way to get here. This usual city-type transportation is not always available; it's expensive; and poor people cannot afford it.

Nunnelly: On these cuts that we've talked about with GSA, the $600,000. What attempts are you planning to make in order to meet these anticipated reduction in funds.

Dr. Rodgers: We're always attempting to get money from other sources - primarily from possible third party payers for medical service, primarily Title 18 and Title 19.

Nunnelly: What is Title 18 and Title 19?

Dr. Rodgers: Title 18 is a part of the government insurance that has to do with persons above 65 years of age. Title 19 is a state controlled counterpart that deals with younger people and welfare recipients; they're put in a category of medical needy persons.

Nunnelly: In other words, the expense of the care is taken care of by the Title 18 and 19?

Dr. Rodgers: In the situation of Title 18, the expenses are pretty well taken care of; Title 19, unfortunately, is a state-controlled activity. The cost is sometimes paid and sometimes it isn't, which is not a very satisfactory system.

Nunnelly: What amounts or what percentage can you expect from such?

Dr. Rodgers: Relatively a small percentage about 6 or 7 percent of the patients are Title 18 eligible and about 25 or 30 percent are Title 19 eligible.

Nunnelly: Would you consider that sizeable?

Dr. Rodgers: In terms of the general budget it's not sizeable. It would be a great help if you added it all up in the course of a year. We suspect it would be at the $300,000 - $400,000 level.

Nunnelly: So it is your anticipation that this amount can in some way equalize the anticipated cut?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, I hope so but I don't really believe so.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers how many people does the Wayne Miner Health Center employ?

Dr. Rodgers: Approximately 200. Nunnelly: How many are sub-professional and professional?

Dr. Rodgers: 50 percent professional and subprofessional.

Nunnelly: What do you see this cutback as having an effect on your employees? Do you feel that some of them may leave thinking that the center is unstable?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, it's certainly upsetting and I hope nobody leaves; but I can understand that they would be concerned about it.

Nunnelly: What about the subprofessionals? Is he in the same boat?

Dr. Rodgers: They probably will react the same way.

Nunnelly: Would you see any big changes, let's say in the Wayne Miner Health Center in the near future that would have any effect on this?

Dr. Rodgers: No, any changes that occur, of course, as we can tell will get here the first of August, 1973. So the immediate future ought to remain stable.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers, are there any other comments that you would like to make either about the health situation in the city, the health situation in the nation or the situation that you are facing at Wayne Miner?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, only that health centers have made a great contribution to health delivery in the country and it's sad if they're discontinued. I hope they won't be.

Nunnelly: Dr. Rodgers you mentioned the neighborhood health centers. What impact has Wayne Miner had on the Kansas City health delivery system?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, it's a difficult question to answer. We can say by virtue of the number of people who come here and apparently have returned. It has given them the feeling that there is a way to deliver health services that is satisfactory and satisfying to patients. We make no claims of saving lives directly because we can't prove it but we're certain that we do.

Nunnelly: One final question. Two years ago you make a statement that the future was bright for this kind of activity, has your feelings in any way changed?

Dr. Rodgers: Well, basically it hasn't changed; it has been modified by virtue of the fact that this kind of activity is dependent on some disinterested persons who make the decisions, that control it; but there's no question the neighborhood health centers, in terms of what they do, are very solid and proven ways to deliver health care.

Nunnelly: Is HEW your only source of funding?

Dr. Rodgers: Basically except for that part we collect from third parties.

Nunnelly: But no grants?

Dr. Rodgers: We have a smaller grant from Regional Medical Program that's for a special purpose, that is the Hi Blood Project. But no foundation or other support.

Reproduced with permission of the copyright owner. Further reproduction prohibited without permission.